THE PAINTER

Game Design Document

Platform: iOS (Unity) — Target: iPhone / iPad

Status: Living Document — Subject to Change

> *Document Note*
> *All character names, locations, story beats, and mechanics described in this document are working drafts.*
> *Names, backstories, and specific details are placeholders and will be revised during development.*
> *The mechanical systems and structural design are the stable foundation; narrative details are subject to change.*

1. Project Overview

Field	Value
Title	The Painter (working title)
Genre	Top-down semi-open world crime / stealth
Platform	iOS (primary) — Android via Unity export (secondary)
Engine	Unity 2D
Language	C#
Developer	Solo
Setting	New York City, 1973
Inspiration	The Irishman, I Heard You Paint Houses, The Godfather, Scarface, The Sopranos, GTA Chinatown Wars

Concept

The Painter is a top-down, semi-open world mobile game in the tradition of GTA Chinatown Wars, with a tone drawn from classic mafia cinema — The Irishman, The Godfather, and The Sopranos. The title is drawn from the Frank Sheeran memoir I Heard You Paint Houses, where 'painting houses' is a euphemism for contract killing: the walls get painted red.

The player takes the role of Vincent Marra, an 18-year-old released from Rikers Island who is recruited by the Cavallo crime family. What begins as a series of jobs to prove himself gradually unravels into a conspiracy that reframes everything Vincent has done — and forces him to reckon with what kind of painter he wants to be.

The game emphasizes stealth, social navigation, and moral consequence over combat. Replayability comes from a mission pool system, a per-contact reputation ladder, and four distinct ending paths determined entirely by the player's choices throughout.

Core Design Pillars

- Small world, deep systems — five zones replace a large open world; every location has meaning
- Reputation over combat — relationships and trust are the primary currency
- Moral ambiguity — no ending is labeled good or bad; the player arrives at one naturally
- Replayability — mission pools, branching contacts, and rep-gated content reward multiple playthroughs
- Mobile-first — touch controls, portrait/landscape support, session-friendly save system

2. Platform & Technical Specifications

Spec	Value
Engine	Unity 6.4 (6000.4.0f1)
Primary platform	iOS — iPhone and iPad
Secondary platform	Android via same Unity project, different export target
Render pipeline	Universal Render Pipeline (URP) 2D
Target frame rate	60 fps
Orientation	Landscape Left
Min iOS version	iOS 14
Distribution	TestFlight (development), App Store (release)
Language	C#
Art style	Top-down 2D sprites, GTA Chinatown Wars aesthetic
Map structure	Single continuous scrolling map — no zone loading screens
Input	Unity Input System — both old and new input handling enabled

Sprite format	RGBA8 PNG, Point (no filter), 16 pixels per unit
Physics	Rigidbody2D, Gravity Scale 0, top-down movement

Touch Control Scheme

Controls mirror the GTA Chinatown Wars layout exactly — fixed positions, two right-hand buttons, minimap top-left, pause top-right. No hidden gestures, no floating elements.

Control	Position	Action
Fixed circular joystick	Bottom left (fixed)	Move Vincent in 8 directions. Cardinal directions play directional animation. Diagonals move diagonally while facing the dominant axis — consistent with Chinatown Wars behavior.
Primary action button	Bottom right (upper)	Interact — talk, enter, pick up, confirm dialog. Also fires weapon when one is equipped.
Secondary action button	Bottom right (lower)	Sprint/sneak toggle and item use — to be finalized in development, following CW conventions.
Minimap	Top left	Always visible. Shows neighborhood layout, objective markers, contact locations, and Caruso's last known position at high rep.
Pause button	Top right	Pause menu — resume, settings, quit to title.
Journal button	Top right (beside pause)	Open casebook — tabbed: case log, active mission, contacts, NPC profiles, finances.

Joystick is fixed bottom-left — same anchor point every session, consistent with Chinatown Wars.
Vincent faces cardinal directions only (up, down, left, right). Diagonal movement uses the dominant axis for facing direction.
Right-hand button layout mirrors Chinatown Wars — two buttons, exact functions tuned during development.
No swipe gestures, no floating controls, no tap-to-move — all input is button and joystick only.

3. World & Map Layout

The neighborhood is one continuous scrolling map — no loading screens or transition points. The five zones exist as distinct areas with their own atmosphere, buildings, and NPCs, but the world is seamless. The camera follows Vincent at all times with a slight lead in the direction of movement, exactly as in GTA Chinatown Wars.

Zone Connections

Zone Border	Notes
Zone A / Zone B	Main Street — wide commercial boundary, naturally busy
Zone A / Zone D	Back alley — narrow, Caruso's patrol crosses here
Zone B / Zone C	Dock road — early access limited by story beat 1
Zone D / Zone C	Canal — runs along southern edge, bridge is the crossing point
Zone D / Zone E	Private road — requires Sal rep 2+ or disguise to move through freely
Zone A / Zone C	No direct path — must navigate through B or D

Note: zones are areas within one continuous map, not separate scenes. All boundaries are organic geographic features — streets, canals, roads — not loading triggers.

Zone A — Social Club + Residential (Hub)

The starting zone. Wide main street running east-west, two side streets, alleyways behind brownstones. Feels lived-in and safe early on. Atmosphere shifts after story beat 1.

Building	Notes
The social club	Hub. Sal is here. Atmosphere shifts per act.
Apartment block A	Ambient. Three enterable units with rotating NPC dialog.
The hardware store	Functional. Buy tools before heading out.
The barbershop	Ambient. Good eavesdropping. One contact meets you here once.
The hidden basement	No mission sends you here. Pure lore reward for explorers.

Zone B — Commercial Strip

The busiest zone. Long commercial block with a side street cutting through the middle. Dense civilian foot traffic creates natural cover. Busiest during day, quieter at night.

Building	Notes
Rizzo's Diner	Lowers suspicion passively. Back office is a mission location.
The pawn shop	Sell items for cash. Fence for certain mission objects.
The laundromat	Sal's front — unlocks at Sal rep 2+. Back room used in several missions.
The pharmacy	Ambient. NPC hints at Zone C.
The parking structure	Elevated sightline. Used in one surveillance mission.

Zone D — Back Streets + Tenements

Tighter and more claustrophobic than Zone A. Narrower streets, more alleyways. A canal runs along the southern edge. Caruso does regular passes — his route is learnable.

Building	Notes
Dena's apartment	Unlocks after mission 1. Key story conversations at rep 2.
Tenement block B	NPC tracks Caruso's movements at rep 1.
Enzo's payphone	Interaction point only. Unlocks beat 1.
The canal walkway	Open space used in two missions as extraction route.
The lockup garage	Enzo rep 2+. Stores mission-critical items in act 3.

Zone C — Waterfront (Unlocks Beat 1)

Wide open loading areas, chain-link fencing, long sightlines. Exposed and industrial. Fewest hiding spots, highest guard density. Final mission plays out entirely here.

Building	Notes
Warehouse A	Partial beat 1, full beat 2. Corkboard showing NPC connections.
Warehouse B	Final story beat mission location.
Loading dock office	Bribeable NPC — gives patrol timing info.
The docked boat	Used in one Enzo mission and the final act.
The gatehouse	Transition back to Zone B. Guard stationed here at night.

Zone E — Affluent District (Unlocks Beat 1)

Wider streets, manicured stoops, fewer civilians but more private security. Vincent doesn't belong here and the environment communicates that.

Building	Notes
Campaign headquarters	Mayor's public face. Front for the back room.
The mayor's residence	Unlocks at mayor rep 2+. Personal conversations happen here.
The private club	Disguise or forged invite required. One surveillance mission.
The law office	Hints at money trail if Dena rep is high.
The park	Open space. One outdoor surveillance mission. Exposed.

4. Characters

All character names and backstories are working placeholders. Roles, relationships, and mechanical functions are stable design.

Vincent Marra — The Player Character

Field	Detail
Age	18-19 at game start
Background	Released from Rikers Island after 1-2 years, convicted at 17
Starting rank	Associate — non-member proving himself to the family
Character arc	Moves from associate toward soldier — which version depends on the player
Key trait	Handled himself inside. Kept quiet. Didn't fold. That's why the lawyer was waiting.

The Lawyer — Consigliere

Field	Detail
Role	Consigliere to the Don — advisor, legal expert, trusted confidant
Mission type	Legal interference — document interception, witness coaching, institutional sabotage
Key trait	Knows the full picture from the start. Every scene is retrospectively interesting.

Crucial reveal	He arranged Vincent's recruitment deliberately — Rikers was engineered

Sal Cavallo — Underboss

Field	Detail
Role	Underboss — second in command, oversees daily operations
Mission type	Field work — extractions, relocations, escorts, physical jobs
Tone	Warm, paternal on the surface. Increasingly complex as the story develops.
Rep rewards	Rep 2: laundromat back room. Rep 3: waterfront and family residence.

Dena Ricci — Bookkeeper

Field	Detail
Role	Family associate — keeps the books, holds no rank, wants none
Mission type	Information work — surveillance, evidence, intercepts
Unlocked	After opening mission
Rep rewards	Rep 2: key story conversation. Rep 3: gives Vincent the full truth.
Key role	Holds the evidence that reframes the entire story at beat 3.

Detective Caruso — The Tail

Field	Detail
Role	NYPD plainclothes — entirely outside the family structure
Mission type	Clean work — disruption, evidence gathering, institutional exposure
Tone	Not corrupt, not stupid. Has been watching the neighborhood for months.
Rep rewards	Rep 3 opens the justice ending path. High Caruso rep burns standing with Sal.

Enzo — The Fixer

Field	Detail

Role	Freelance — operates outside family structure, no allegiance
Mission type	High-risk, high-reward work. Unlocks at story beat 1.
Tone	Cold, mercenary. Takes jobs the family pretends don't exist.
Rep consequences	Taking his work drains rep with Caruso. High Enzo rep unlocks assassination ending.
Access point	A payphone in Zone D. No building.

The Mayoral Candidate

Field	Detail
Role	Reform mayoral candidate — charismatic, partially compromised
Relationship	Taking family money, asking few questions
Mission type	Political operations — envelopes, intercepts, disruption
Beat 2 outcome	Elected, arrested, or assassinated — depends on missions and rep profile

5. Story Structure

Story beats trigger based on total missions completed, not which specific missions. The player chooses order freely.

Opening — Release Day (Fixed)

Vincent walks out of Rikers. The lawyer is waiting. One introductory mission: relocate Dena Ricci to a safehouse. Teaches movement, interaction, and the suspicion system. Dena becomes a contact. Zones A and B accessible.

Story Beat 1 — The Introduction (After 4 side missions)

The lawyer introduces Vincent to Sal at the social club. Zone E unlocks. The mayoral candidate becomes a contact. Enzo surfaces in Zone D. The dock road to Zone C partially opens.

Story Beat 2 — Election Night (After 10 side missions)

The mayoral election lands. Three possible outcomes based on missions completed and rep profile:

Outcome	Consequence
Elected	Zone E becomes more guarded. The mayor begins distancing from Sal. Internal threat emerges.
Arrested	Caruso or Dena's missions gave someone enough to act. Family scrambles. Vincent becomes a loose end.
Assassinated	Requires sufficient Enzo rep and a specific act 1 mission. Zone E locks permanently.

Story Beat 3 — The Revelation (After 16 side missions)

Dena surfaces with the complete picture — the money trail, the family's fingerprints on the campaign, and the name of whoever inside the family arranged Vincent's conviction at 17. It was not random. He was set up, watched, and recruited deliberately. The lawyer knew. Zone C fully unlocks.

Story Beat 4 — The Thread (After 20 missions or manually after beat 3)

The final mission. Its shape depends entirely on the rep profile built across the whole game and which mayor outcome occurred at beat 2. Four distinct final missions — no two playthroughs guaranteed to reach the same one.

6. Ending Paths

No ending is labeled good or bad. The player arrives at one naturally based on who they spent the game working for.

Ending	Name	Required Rep	Outcome
A	The Loyalist	High Sal	Vincent protects the family. He stays. Becomes a made man. Nothing changes — that is the point.
B	The Conscience	High Caruso + Dena	Vincent delivers everything to Caruso. Burns every bridge and leaves. The cleanest ending morally, the costliest personally.
C	The Professional	High Enzo	Vincent removes the problem. No trial, no exposure. Gets paid and feels nothing. Darkest ending.
D	The Ghost	Balanced across all	Vincent knows too much to stay and too little to act. He disappears. Most ambiguous, hardest to reach.

7. Core Gameplay Systems

Reputation System

Each of the five contacts has a separate reputation score on a 0-3 scale. Rep is gained by completing missions cleanly. The player cannot max all contacts in one playthrough.

Level	Symbol	Effect
0	○○○	Cold — one mission available, no building access, minimal dialog
1	●○○	Standard — full mission pool unlocked, contact opens up
2	●●○	Trusted — new building access, harder missions, personal story revealed
3	●●●	Full trust — contact's arc completes, unique ending path available

Mission Pool System

Each contact has a pool of 8-12 authored missions. Each playthrough draws from the pool with randomized variables: target location, target NPC, and a complication modifier. A single playthrough sees roughly 12 missions from a pool of 30+, leaving substantial content for replays.

Variable	Examples
Location	4-5 buildings per zone drawn randomly
Complication	Guard presence doubled, time limit active, Caruso is watching, rain reduces NPC visibility, target is already spooked

Stealth System

- Enemy detection cones — visible, blocked by dense cover
- Three alert states: unaware, suspicious, hunting — drops over time if player breaks line of sight
- Noise radius — affected by movement speed
- Suspicion meter — fills near guards or when civilians witness incidents, drains when player leaves area
- Stealth zones — flagged tiles that auto-switch movement mode from sprint to sneak

Item Inventory

Four items maximum per mission, selected before heading out. Cannot swap mid-mission. Forces strategic planning.

Tool	Function
Camera	Photograph targets for evidence missions
Spare key set	Bypass a locked door once per mission
Bribe envelope	Pay off a civilian witness
Distraction item	Noise draw — pulls a guard off their route
Disguise	Changes NPC recognition for a limited time
Weapon (act 3+)	Lethal option. Available only in certain missions.

Consequence Flags

Binary flags track key choices across missions — 3-4 boolean variables that the final mission reads. Did Caruso see Vincent's face? Is Dena cooperative or hostile? Was the ledger fully destroyed? Each flag opens or closes one path in the ending. No explicit morality meter is shown.

8. Contact Mission Types

Contact	Mission Type	Sample Missions
Sal Cavallo	Field work	Move witness, intercept courier, extract burned soldier, escort Sal's nephew
Dena Ricci	Information	Photograph meeting, retrieve ledger page, plant listening device, tail a mark
The Lawyer	Legal interference	Document interception, witness coaching, evidence suppression
Detective Caruso	Clean work	Gather evidence, sabotage delivery, surveil city official, plant anonymous tip
Enzo	High risk	Destroy evidence before sweep, recover stolen property, disrupt a meeting, waterfront job
The Mayor	Political ops	Deliver envelope to union rep, intercept journalist's source, disrupt rival event

9. Development Notes

Toolchain

Tool	Purpose
Unity 6.4	Primary engine — 2D URP pipeline
C#	Primary language — scripting, game logic
Unity Tilemaps	Zone layout and collision
Unity Animator	Sprite animation state machine
Unity Input System	Touch controls, virtual joystick
Xcode	iOS build and TestFlight distribution
Android Build Support	Secondary export target (same project)

Recommended Build Order

1. [DONE] Unity 6.4 project setup — 2D URP, iOS build target, Landscape Left orientation
2. [DONE] Vincent on screen — sprite import, automatic slicing, Sprite Renderer
3. [DONE] 8-directional movement — PlayerController, Rigidbody2D, GetAxisRaw input
4. [DONE] Directional animation — 6 clips (idle/run x down/up/side), Animator controller
5. [DONE] Camera follow — CameraFollow script, smooth lerp, offset -10 on Z
6. Touch controls — virtual joystick (fixed bottom-left), action buttons (bottom-right)
7. Tilemap — continuous neighborhood map, collision layer, ground tiles
8. Basic UI — suspicion meter, item wheel, journal button
9. NPC system — simple patrol AI, interaction trigger
10. Stealth system — detection cones, alert states, suspicion meter
11. Mission system — mission struct, one complete mission end-to-end
12. Reputation system — per-contact rep tracking, rep-gated content
13. Story beat system — mission count tracking, beat triggers
14. Audio — ambient music per zone, sound effects
15. Ending system — consequence flags, final mission branching
16. Polish pass — touch feel, performance profiling, TestFlight beta

Replayability summary
A single playthrough completes roughly 12 side missions out of a pool of 30+, maxes 1-2 contacts out of 5, and reaches one of four endings.
A second playthrough with different contact priorities produces meaningfully different missions, building access, and a different picture of what actually happened.